

Introduction

This project explores whether students who are likely to have entered higher education as mature students report different university experiences from those who are more likely to have entered directly from school or sixth form. Due to the available survey categories, students aged 26 and over were used as a proxy for mature students, while students aged 21 and under were used as a proxy for traditional entrants.

Data Source

The Student Academic Experience Survey 2025

<https://www.hepi.ac.uk/reports/student-academic-experience-survey-2025/>

https://www.hepi.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/SAES-2025_FINAL_WEB.pdf

<https://www.hepi.ac.uk/wp-content/uploads/2025/06/SAES-data-tables-2025.xlsx>

Methodology

Initially I tried to import the data directly from excel into R using “read_excel()”. However the Excel file had been designed for human readability rather than a straightforward data extraction and analysis. It contains multiple tables, merged cells, blank rows, and formatting elements that made it difficult to isolate the variables required.

I then tried to isolate individual tables, but the formatting issues remained. As a result, I manually entered the relevant survey data into R using matrices.

Defining mature students

Ideally, I wanted to compare students aged 21 and over who had started their first year aged 21 with students who had started university straight after further education. The typical definition of a mature student in the UK is a student who is aged 21 or older when they start their undergraduate studies.

<https://www.ucas.com/applying/applying-university/mature-students>

However, the survey only reported the age groups as: 21 and under, 22-25, and 26 and over.

The 22-25 group may have contained students who entered university at the traditional age and are in their later years of study. For this reason, and to focus on students who were more likely to have entered higher education as mature students, I only compared the 21 and under group with the 26 and over group.

Selection of Survey Questions

The Student Academic Experience Survey contains a large number of questions covering different aspects of higher education. As this was my first independent project in R, I deliberately selected just three questions. This allowed me to focus on learning fundamental skills such as creating matrices, subsetting data, and producing visualisations without becoming overwhelmed by the size and complexity of the full data set.

Question 1: “Overall, how satisfied are you with your life nowadays?”

I selected this question because it provides a broad measure of wellbeing. Although it is not exclusively about university, university forms a significant part of many students' lives and can influence overall life satisfaction.

Question 2: Thinking back to when you applied to your current university, has the reality of your academic experience met your expectations?

I selected this question because it focuses specifically on the educational experience. As someone who previously attended university before leaving and later returning to higher education, I was interested in whether mature students were more likely to feel that university met or exceeded their expectations.

Question 3: Thinking of all the things you've been asked about in this survey so far, which statement best describes your view of the value for money of your present course?

I selected this question because tuition fees and living costs are an important part of the student experience. I was interested in whether mature students, who may have different financial experiences and expectations, viewed value for money differently from younger students.

Findings

The findings below are based on visual comparisons of the survey data and are just observations rather than statistically tested conclusions.

Overall life satisfaction

The data suggested that students aged 26 and over reported slightly higher levels of life satisfaction than students aged 21 and under. Mature students were more likely to select the highest satisfaction scores and less likely to report lower levels of satisfaction.

One possible explanation is that mature students may enter higher education with greater life experience and a clearer sense of purpose.

Academic Expectations

Students aged 26 and over were more likely to report that their academic experience had been better than expected.

This may reflect the fact that mature students often make a more deliberate decision to enter higher education and may therefore have different expectations when beginning their studies.

Value for Money

Students aged 21 and under were more likely to report that their course represented good or very good value for money. Students aged 26 and over were more likely to report poorer value for money ratings.

This may reflect differences in financial circumstances, opportunity costs, or expectations regarding the benefits of higher education.

Limitations

Study Routes

The survey includes students studying through a range of routes, including foundation certificates or degrees, degree apprenticeships, CertHE or DipHE, HNC or HND as well as traditional bachelor degrees and integrated masters. The analysis therefore reflects the wider survey population rather than only full-time undergraduate degree students.

Selection of Survey Questions

As only three questions were chosen, the analysis does not capture all aspects of the student experience. The Student Academic Experience Survey includes a much wider range of topics, including teaching quality, workload, assessment, mental health, financial pressures, and more. It also highlights what factors students might have been considering when answering the questions on satisfaction, experience versus expectations, and value for money.

The selection of questions was also influenced by my own experience of leaving university and later returning to higher education. While this personal connection helped motivate the project, it may have influenced which aspects of the student experience I considered most important to investigate.

Limiting the analysis to three questions reduces the depth of the findings, and the results should not be interpreted as a complete measure of student satisfaction. Readers seeking a more comprehensive understanding of student experiences should refer to the original Student Academic Experience Survey report and data tables.

Satisfaction index

I considered creating a combined satisfaction score across all survey measures. However the questions used different response scales and constructing a composite index would have required assumptions regarding weighting and scoring.

I found it difficult to create a combined measure that represented the underlying survey data. As this was an introductory R project focused on developing my personal skills, I decided to analyse each measure separately rather than introduce a potentially misleading overall score.

Developing more sophisticated methods for combining and analysing survey measures is something I hope to explore further in my Social Sciences with Data Science degree at UCL.

Skills Learned and Future Development

During this project I practised:

- Creating matrices in R
- Indexing and subsetting matrices
- Creating bar charts

- Applying custom colour schemes
- Working with large scale survey data
- Data cleaning and preparation
- Basic data visualisation
- Interpreting results
- Project Documentation

Future improvements could include:

- Importing and cleaning survey data directly from Excel
- Creating a composite satisfaction index
- Using data frames instead of manually entered matrices
- Applying statistical analysis to test whether observed differences are significant
- Expanding the number of variables analysed